



Thresan

SKYFLAG

Where strategists gather.

THREE LAYERS · FOUR LIFTS · ONE NEXUS

RULEBOOK · v22 · CROSS-BOARD RULE

2 players · ages 8+ · 45-75 minutes

Foreword

From SkyFlag to Thresan

Thresan™ is a strategy game. Skyflag is its current edition: the pieces, the boards, and the storyboard set in the world of Kaleo. The rules in this book describe Thresan; the names, art, and narrative describe Skyflag. Future editions of Thresan may rename the pieces, redress the boards, and rewrite the world. The rules will not change. This game began life in 2026 under the working title SkyFlag. The world, the pieces, the geometry, and the spirit of play are unchanged; the brand has matured. In the world of Kaleo, Skyflag is not merely a game. It is the lawful contest by which the clans test reach, continuity, and command across the three layers of the arcology: Terran, Meridian, and Empyrean. Every campaign restages the ancient Aetheri proof. Every move asks the same question: which claimant can command the full depth of the world?

The Ashtapada lineage

Thresan: Skyflag is the latest expression of a strategy-board tradition that begins, in the documented record, with Ashtapada (Ashtāpada), the ancient Indian eight-footed race game referenced in the Pali Brahma-jala Sutta of the 5th century BCE and later used as the board for Chaturanga, the immediate ancestor of chess. H.J.R. Murray, in his 1913 A History of Chess, credited Ashtapada as a progenitor of abstract strategy games. The 6×6×3 architecture of Thresan: Skyflag is original. The lineage it claims is ancient. Heritage and design notes at ashtapada.com.

Everything in the rulebook v19.1 (Cross-Board Rule, Edition 1.1), v20, and v21 is preserved in v22. What was added in v20 came from a year of playing the game across solo, two-player hot-seat, and online formats, additions that support the core geometry rather than alter it. v21 was a brand-only update. v22 sharpens the win-condition language into two explicit paths, codifies several edge-case rulings surfaced during the digital build, and adds the constructive-proof framing that distinguishes Thresan from its chess ancestors. No rule has changed in substance; v22 makes precise what earlier editions left implicit.

v20 additions (preserved in v22)

Addition	Effect on the core game
Time controls (5 / 10 / 30 min)	Optional. Off by default; identical core rules.
Resignation and draw offers	Either player may resign or offer a draw at any time.
AI difficulty levels	Easy / Medium / Hard / Expert. Solo play only.
Online multiplayer	Rated games, friends, tournaments. Same rules.
Daily Puzzle	One shared tactical position per day. Single-side,

Addition	Effect on the core game
	race-the-clock.

Kaleo

A world above a world that failed

Long ago, when the planet below gave way to salt, dust, and ruined basins, the Aetheri lifted what remained of civilization into a three-layer arcology. The lowest layer, the Terran, holds the reservoirs, farms, workshops, and crowded human districts. Above it, the Meridian carries charged air, transit architecture, and the old routing systems. At the summit rests the Empyrean, the quiet upper shell where the Aetheri left their highest instruments.

At the centre of the Empyrean, and only there, waits the Caelum Nexus. The lower layers have no such central shrine. What they have, instead, are corners.

Each clan placed three dormant claim-seals in the corners of its own territory on each layer, proofs of presence left for the Aetheri to witness. Defend your seals; the opponent's seals are your targets. Only by crossing into the opposing clan's territory and neutralizing all three of its seals may a Captain earn the right to approach the Nexus. The Aetheri did not trust survival to strength alone; they built Kaleo as a system of proofs, and the proof demanded is reach.

In the deepest Aetheri archives the proof is named Ashtapada, the eight-footed inheritance the Aetheri carried with them from the worlds before Kaleo. Thresan is what the Aetheri made of Ashtapada when they built the arcology: the eight-footed proof translated into three layers and four Lifts.



“The Aetheri did not build three layers. They built three answers to the same question.”

The Two Clans

For seven generations, Kaleo was one people. The schism came during a crisis whose name the archives still record, a disease that tore through the lower districts while the council debated what to do. One faction argued for immediate escalation: open the Aetheri archives, petition the Nexus. The other argued for containment: preserve what remained, refuse panic, work with the tools already at hand.

The containment faction won the argument by one vote. Their victory stabilized Kaleo at the cost of two hundred thousand Terran residents who might have been saved. The escalation faction did not forget. Over four generations they consolidated into the Grey Ravens. The faction that had won became the White Stags. Each clan drew its name and totem from the temperament that had defined its position in that ancient debate.

Six generations later, both clans still claim duty. Both claim restraint. Both claim they are acting for Kaleo. Both are correct. Neither is complete. The contest that decides Kaleo's next age is the raid on the opposing clan's three seals, and the answer of the Nexus.



GREY RAVENS

"We have been here longer than the crisis. We will be here longer than its answer."

WHITE STAGS

"We were given a path. If we do not walk it, it becomes a monument to our refusal."

Contents

This rulebook proceeds in the order you will need it. If you are sitting down to your first game, read sections 1 through 4 before setup. Section 10 is a single-page reference designed to live beside the board during play. Sections marked NEW are additions in v20.

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1 • Overview

Thresan: Skyflag is a two-player tactical race played across a three-layer arcology. Each player commands four pieces (a Captain, a Soldier, a Rover, and a Pilot) and pursues victory by one of two paths. The first path is constructive: capture all three of the opponent's claim-flags, one on each layer, then land your Captain on the Caelum Nexus at Space(3,3). The second path is eliminative: remove every Captain-capable piece your opponent has, on the board, in hand, and the Soldier that could still promote. Both paths are demonstrations of reach. Both are won by judgment, not by luck. Thresan is, in the language of the Aetheri, a constructive proof, the opposite of the contradiction proof at the heart of chess.

Pieces move and capture by geometry alone. There are no special abilities, no cards, no dice. Everything the game offers comes from the interaction of four movement profiles with the architecture of three stacked boards and the four vertical transit points, the Lifts, that connect them.

THE OBJECTIVE

Win by either of two paths. Path of Three: capture the opponent's three flags, one on each layer, in any order, then land your Captain on the Nexus at Space(3,3). Path of the Captain: eliminate every Captain-capable piece your opponent has (no Captain on the board or in hand, and no Soldier that could still promote).

Board coordinates

All three layers share the same coordinate system. A cell is identified as Layer(row, col). Row 0 is the top edge; row 5 is the bottom. Col 0 is the left edge; col 5 is the right.

Layer	In-world name	Notable feature
Ground	Terran	Starting layer, pieces deploy here.
Sky	Meridian	Middle transit layer. Most contested phase.
Space	Empyrean	Contains the Nexus at Space(3,3).

2 · Components and Setup

Components

Item	Quantity and notes
Three-layer board	Ground, Sky, and Space, each a 6×6 grid sharing coordinates.
Player pieces	4 per player: Captain, Soldier, Rover, Pilot. P1 = slate; P2 = ivory.
Flag markers	3 per player: Ground Flag (🚩), Sky Flag (🚩), Space Flag (★).
Lift tokens	12 total, four per layer, marking the Lift cells.
Nexus marker	1, placed at Space(3,3).

The Board

The board comprises three stacked 6×6 layers. Four Lifts at (1,1), (1,4), (4,1), (4,4) connect every layer. Flag positions are fixed and symmetric for the two players.

GROUND · THE TERRAN LAYER

	c0	c1	c2	c3	c4	c5
r0	🚩P1			●P1		
r1		↑			↑	
r2						
r3						
r4		↑			↑	
r5			●P2			🚩P2

P1 Ground Flag at G(0,0); P2 at G(5,5). Captains start: P1 G(0,3), P2 G(5,2). Lifts at (1,1), (1,4), (4,1), (4,4).

SKY · THE MERIDIAN LAYER

	c0	c1	c2	c3	c4	c5
r0						🚩P1
r1		↑			↑	
r2						
r3						

r4		↑			↑	
r5	♣P2					

P1 Sky Flag at Sky(0,5); P2 at Sky(5,0), diagonally opposite.

SPACE · THE EMPYREAN LAYER

	c0	c1	c2	c3	c4	c5
r0	★P1					
r1		↑			↑	
r2						
r3				⊙		
r4		↑			↑	
r5						★P2

*P1 Space Flag at Space(0,0); P2 at Space(5,5). Each echoes the Ground Flag corner (the Aetheri Echo Point).
The Nexus sits at Space(3,3).*

LIFTS: ALL LAYERS

The four Lift positions are the same on all three layers: (1,1), (1,4), (4,1), and (4,4). No two Lifts are within king-move of each other. A Captain cannot threaten two Lifts from a single position. Lift defence is by positioning, not cluster control.

Setup

Element	P1 · Slate	P2 · Ivory	Notes
Captain start	Ground (0,3)	Ground (5,2)	In hand; deploy costs 1 activation.
Soldier	In hand	In hand	Deploy during play, 1 activation.
Rover	In hand	In hand	Deploy during play, 1 activation.
Pilot	In hand	In hand	Deploy during play, 1 activation.
Ground Flag	G(0,0)	G(5,5)	Place at each player's corner.
Sky Flag	Sky(0,5)	Sky(5,0)	Opposite corner on the Sky layer.
Space Flag	Space(0,0)	Space(5,5)	Echoes the Ground Flag corner.
Nexus	Space(3,3)	Space(3,3)	Shared finish cell.

Element	P1 · Slate	P2 · Ivory	Notes
Activations	2 per turn	2 per turn	Both players start with the same budget.

SETUP STEPS

1. Place 12 Lift tokens, 4 per layer at (1,1), (1,4), (4,1), and (4,4).
2. Place P1 flags at G(0,0), Sky(0,5), Space(0,0). Place P2 flags at G(5,5), Sky(5,0), Space(5,5).
3. Place the Nexus marker at Space(3,3).
4. All pieces (Captain, Soldier, Rover, Pilot) start in hand. Determine the first player by any mutual method.
5. Each turn, both players have 2 activations.

3 • The Four Pieces

All tactical power comes from movement, capture geometry, and positioning. Pieces use the same movement on every layer. The summary table below is followed by a detailed card for each piece.

Piece	Movement	Capture	Role
Captain	King-move: 1 sq in any of 8 directions.	Lands on opponent's cell.	Win-capable. Captures flags and lands on Space(3,3) to finish.
Soldier	Forward only. First move ≤ 2 sq; subsequent 1 sq.	1 sq diagonally forward.	Deploys from hand. Promotes to Captain at the far row on Ground.
Rover	Orthogonal ≤ 2 sq.	1 step only, cannot capture at 2 squares.	Lift-corridor guard. Blocks approaches.
Pilot	Diagonal ≤ 2 sq. May jump over an intervening piece.	Lands on opponent beyond the jump; jumped piece captured.	Flanks Lift approaches. Reaches threats over defenders.

3. THE FOUR PIECES

Each player commands four pieces. They move and capture by geometry, not by cards or dice.



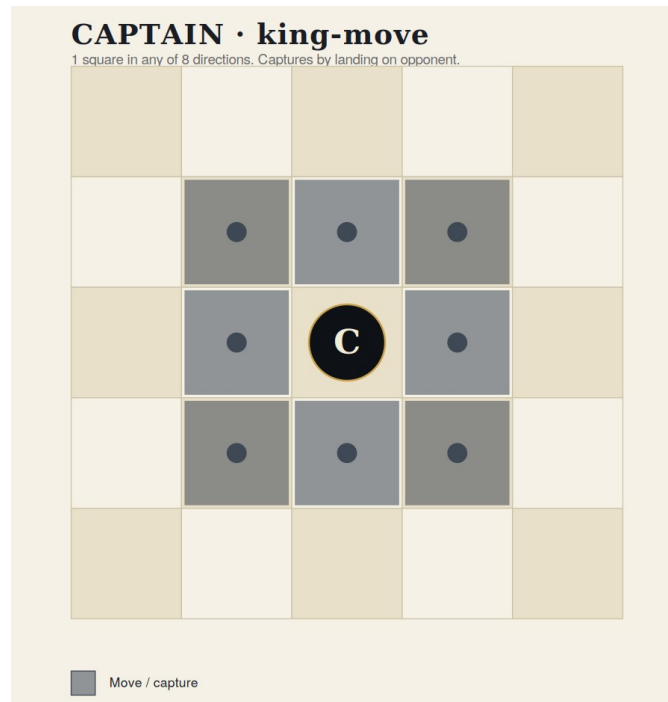
CAPTAIN The Commander	ROVER The Pathfinder	PILOT The Skirmisher	SOLDIER The Vanguard
Leads the claim. Moves with full freedom in any direction.	Controls routes and corridors. Moves orthogonally with precision.	Strikes along diagonals with speed and precision.	Advances the line. Moves forward with discipline.
MOVEMENT Up to 1 cell in any of the 8 surrounding directions. CAPTURE Capture by landing on a cell occupied by an enemy piece.	MOVEMENT Up to 1 or 2 cells orthogonally (straight lines only). CAPTURE Capture only on the 1-cell move (not on the 2-cell move).	MOVEMENT Up to 1 or 2 cells diagonally. CAPTURE May jump over exactly one enemy piece (on the 2-cell move) and land beyond it to capture.	MOVEMENT Moves forward only. CAPTURE Capture 1 cell diagonally forward.
PROMOTION When a Soldier reaches the far edge of the Ground layer (row 5 for P1, row 0 for P2), it is promoted to a Captain. It immediately gains Captain movement and capture rules. ALL PIECES No special abilities. No cards. No dice. Geometry decides everything.			

Captain • Dantec

Slate: Renn Dantec · Ivory: Sera Dantec

The only piece, along with a promoted Soldier, that can capture flags and answer the Nexus. Every other piece exists to protect her approach.

Movement	1 square in any of 8 directions (king-move). All layers.
Capture	By landing on the opponent's cell.
Role	Win-capable. Captures flags. Finishes the game at Space(3,3).



THE CAPTAIN

LEADER. CLAIMANT. DECIDER.

The Captain is your leader and your victory condition. Only the Captain can land on the Nexus at Space(3,3) after all three enemy flags have been captured.



MOVEMENT PROFILE



Orthogonal any number of space in a straight line.



CAPTURE

Land on an enemy flag to capture it.



COMMAND PRESENCE

Your Captain's position shapes the battle and your options.



VICTORY

Capture all three enemy flags, then land on the Nexus at Space(3,3) to win.



*"A Captain does not seek paths.
A Captain creates the only one
that matters."*



Soldier · Durren

Slate: Toren Durren · Ivory: Kael Durren

Deploys from hand. Forward-only. A Soldier that reaches the back rank on Ground changes the game: a second win-capable piece appears on the board.

Movement	Forward only (P1 down rows; P2 up rows). First move ≤ 2 sq; subsequent 1 sq.
Capture	1 square diagonally forward only.
Role	Controls approach corridors. Promotes to Captain at the far row.

SOLDIER PROMOTION

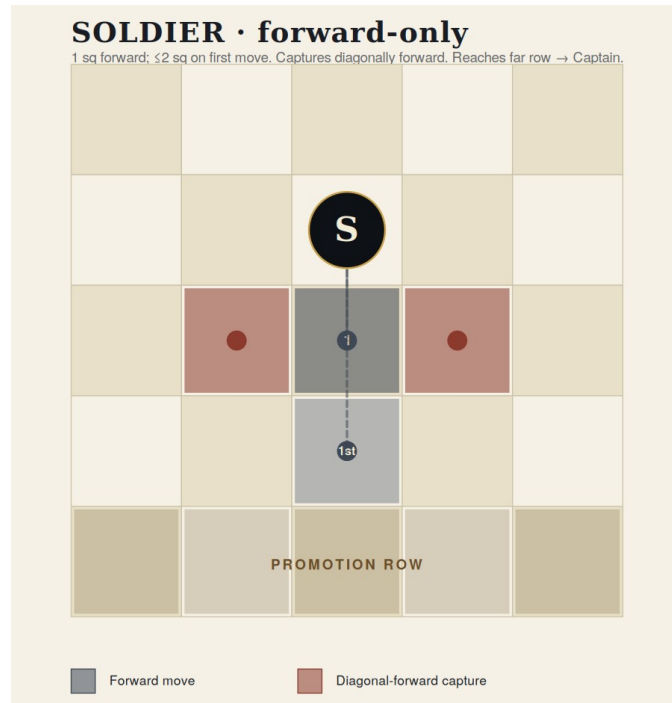
When a Soldier reaches the far row on the Ground layer (row 5 for P1; row 0 for P2), it promotes immediately to a Captain. A promoted Captain has full Captain powers: it may capture flags and land on Space(3,3) to finish the game.

Flag-capture progress is shared across both Captains, you do not need to capture all three flags with the same Captain. Players may therefore field up to two Captains simultaneously.

LORE · THE TEMPLATE-WAKE

In the world of Kaleo, the Aetheri designed the Durren template to accommodate in-field promotion to the Dantec template. Every Durren operative carries a latent Dantec implant at the base of the skull, inactive since the operative's original training. A Durren who completes a full-depth traverse of the Terran under live opposition has demonstrated the judgment the Dantec template requires. At that moment the implant wakes.

Both clans brief their Durren operatives on what to expect: a brief disorientation, a warmth at the base of the skull, a sudden expansion of available tactical options, and the recognition that one has become, under Aetheri law, a lawful claimant. The wake takes about four seconds. The Durren is, for those seconds, both things at once. Then it settles. The protocol carries risk. Of twelve Durrens who have attempted the crossing in recorded history, seven survived to row five; of those, four were waked successfully and three collapsed within a round of activation. The White Stags consider the rate acceptable. The Grey Ravens do not. The cultural argument between the clans is, in part, an argument about that number.



THE SOLDIER

ADVANCE. HOLD. STRIKE.

The Soldier is your instrument of pressure and control. Use your Soldier to advance, capture flags, block enemy movement, and support your Captain.

MOVEMENT PROFILE

Orthogonal any number of spaces.

CAPTURE
Land on an enemy flag to capture it.

ZONE CONTROL
Control key lanes and threaten multiple directions.

SUPPORT
Work with your pieces to open routes and secure sectors.

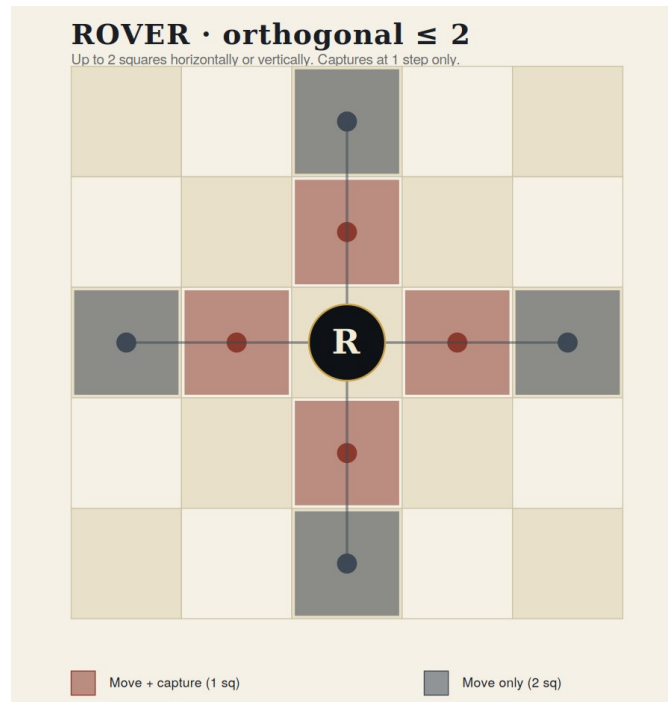
"Discipline is not the absence of urgency. It is the weapon that makes urgency useful."

Rover · Thandiwe

Slate: Mox Thandiwe · Ivory: Iva Thandiwe

Rovers lock down Lift corridors and force the opponent to reroute. A Rover does not need to strike, a Rover only needs to stand in the correct place.

Movement	Orthogonal ≤ 2 squares (horizontally or vertically). All layers.
Capture	1 step only, cannot capture at 2 squares.
Role	Limited rook. Corridor control. Lift defence.



THE ROVER

SCOUT. CONTROL. OUTMANEUVER.

The Rover reads the routes others miss. Use your Rover's speed and vision to control key lanes, capture flags, and deny enemy movement.

 **MOVEMENT PROFILE**



Orthogonal any number of spaces.

 **CAPTURE**

Land on an enemy flag to capture it.

 **INTEL & CONTROL**

Reveal lanes, threaten routes, and shape the flow of battle.

 **MOBILITY**

Move across layers and around obstacles to reach what others cannot.

*"Information is movement.
Movement is advantage.
Advantage decides everything."*



Pilot · Voss

Slate: Zara Voss · Ivory: Arin Voss

The Pilot converts a screen into a liability. The one piece that reaches a threat over defending pieces, arriving one square sooner than the defender expected.

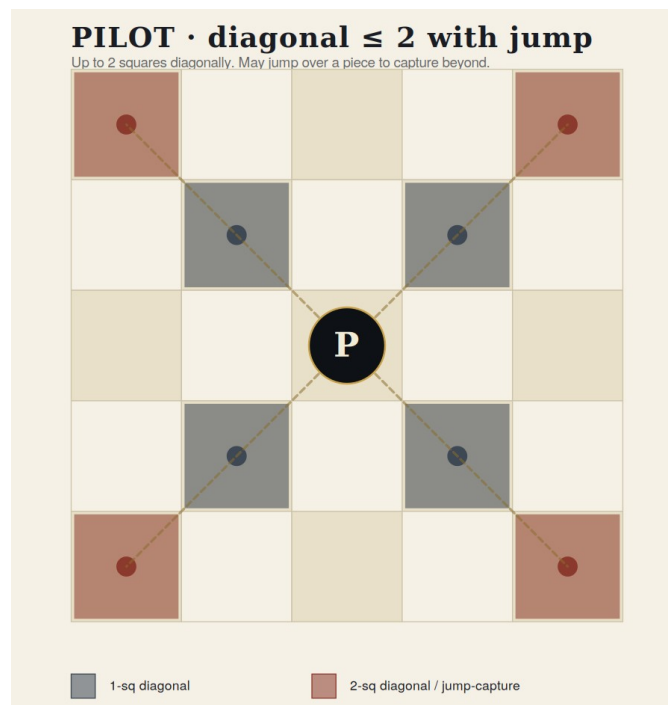
Movement	Diagonal ≤ 2 squares. May jump over an intervening piece.
Capture	Lands on opponent beyond the jump; the jumped piece is captured.
Role	Limited bishop with jump-capture. Flanks Lift approaches.

PILOT JUMP DETAILS

A Pilot at A may jump to C if there is exactly one piece (friend or enemy) at B, where $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$ is a straight diagonal of 2 squares. If C holds an enemy piece, both that piece and the jumped piece at B are captured.

If C is empty, the move is legal; the Pilot still passes over the jumped piece but only the jumped piece is captured.

A Pilot cannot jump over more than one piece, and cannot end its move on a square occupied by a friendly piece.



THE PILOT

ELEVATE. REPOSITION. STRIKE.

The Pilot moves above the battle. Use your Pilot's mobility to cross obstacles, reach critical spaces, capture flags, and change the game.

 **MOVEMENT PROFILE**



Orthogonal any number of spaces.

 **CAPTURE**

Land on an enemy flag to capture it.

 **ELEVATE & CROSS**

Fly over pieces and obstacles. Ignore blocking.

 **REPOSITION**

Reach distant zones, reinforce fronts, and create opportunities.

 **MOBILITY**

You are never where the enemy expects you to be.

*"From above, the path is clear.
From above, the future is
in reach."*



4 • Turn Sequence

Each turn proceeds through the following steps in order. You must take every action available within your activation budget; you cannot pass if a legal action exists.

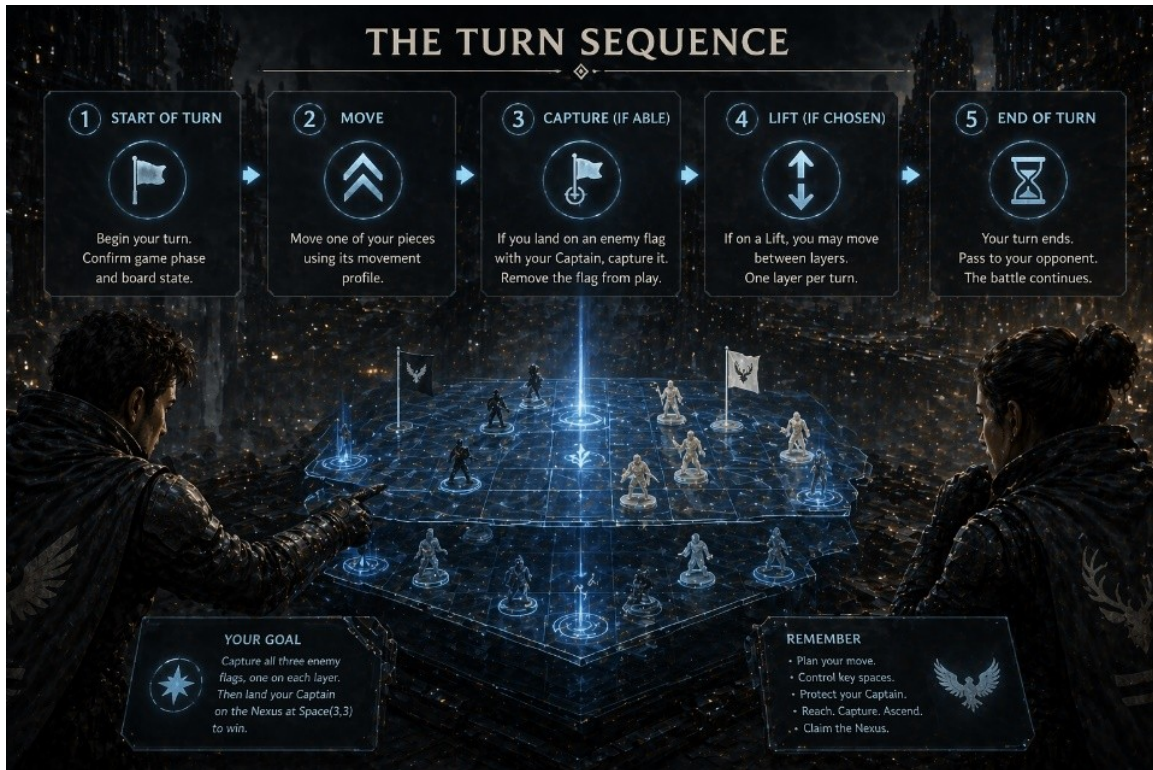
Step	What you do
1 • Deploy (optional)	Place 1 piece from hand onto your starting cell on the Ground layer. Costs 1 activation. A newly deployed piece cannot move on the same activation.
2 • Activate	Take up to 2 actions with deployed pieces. Each action is one of: move a piece, capture, step up or down a Lift. You must act if any legal action is available.
3 • Flag check	If one of your Captains (original or promoted) just landed on a cell containing an opponent's flag, capture it immediately. Remove the flag marker.
4 • Nexus check	If all three of your opponent's flags have been captured and one of your Captains just landed on Space(3,3), you win immediately.
5 • Pass initiative	The other player now takes their turn.

ACTIVATION SUMMARY

Standard: 2 activations per turn for both players.

Lift use: move to a Lift cell (1 activation on one turn), then step up or down one layer (1 activation on the next turn). The Lift step itself cannot capture.

Flag capture is automatic at step 3; it does not consume an activation, and it grants no bonus activation.



Stylized overview. Definitive rules are in the table and callout above.

5 • The Lifts

Lifts connect the three layers. They always occupy the same (row, col) on each layer: (1,1), (1,4), (4,1), and (4,4). These four positions form a square ring inside the board, each exactly one king-move from a flag corner on the Ground layer.

USING A LIFT: TWO TURNS

Using a Lift takes two separate activations on two separate turns:

Turn A: move your piece onto the Lift cell on its current layer (1 activation).

Turn B: step your piece up or down one layer via that Lift (1 activation).

A piece cannot arrive at a Lift and step through it in the same activation. Exception: if a piece ends a turn already on a Lift cell, it may step up or down on its very next activation.

LIFT OCCUPATION RULE

A piece on a Lift cell on one layer blocks the Lift step from the adjacent layer. The blocking piece does not need to be on the same Lift cell as the ascending piece; it needs to be at the same (row, col) on the layer above or below.

The blocked Lift step cannot capture the blocking piece. To clear a blocked Lift, remove the blocking piece through normal play on its own layer.

Strategy: parking a defender on the Space Lift above your own flag (P1: Space(1,1); P2: Space(4,4)) simultaneously guards the approach AND blocks that Lift from Sky, denying the opponent an ascent.

LIFT EDGE CASE: CAPTURE AND TRANSIT

When an opposing piece occupies a Lift cell, the resolution depends on its layer relative to your moving piece.

Same layer (capture): If the opposing piece is on the Lift cell on your moving piece's own layer, your piece may capture it by normal movement rules (1 activation), arriving on the Lift cell. The Lift step itself is a separate activation. If activation budget remains on the same turn, the now-occupying piece may step up or down via the Lift.

Above or below (blocks transit): If the opposing piece is at the same (row, col) on the layer immediately above or below your moving piece's Lift cell, the Lift step is blocked. The Lift step cannot capture; you cannot ascend or descend into an occupied cell. To clear the block, the opposing piece must be removed through normal play on its own layer first.

Lift independence: no two Lifts are within king-move of each other. A piece on one Lift cell cannot threaten any other Lift. There is no cluster fortress; each Lift must be defended individually through positioning.



6 • The Flags and the Nexus

The Path of Three is the principal route to victory. Each player captures the opponent's three flags, placed in the opponent's corners. Landing on your own flag cell does nothing; your flag stays in place until the opponent captures it. Flags may be captured in any order; Ground, Sky, and Space are fully independent objectives. Once all three of the opponent's flags are captured, your Captain must reach the Nexus at Space(3,3) to win. A Captain that arrives at the Nexus before completing the flag chain has not won; the cell registers no claim until the chain is whole. The alternative path, by elimination of Captain-capable pieces, is covered in §7.

Element	P1 · Slate (targets)	P2 · Ivory (targets)
Ground Flag	G(5,5), bottom-right	G(0,0), top-left
Sky Flag	Sky(5,0), bottom-left	Sky(0,5), top-right
Space Flag	Space(5,5), bottom-right	Space(0,0), top-left
Nearest Lift	(4,4) for G and Space; (4,1) for Sky	(1,1) for G and Space; (1,4) for Sky
Nexus	Space(3,3), shared finish cell	Space(3,3), shared finish cell

FLAG CAPTURE

A Captain (original or promoted) lands on an opponent's flag cell, and the flag is captured instantly. Remove the marker. A friendly or enemy piece on the flag cell does NOT block capture; a Captain may always land on and capture an opponent's flag regardless of who else occupies it.

Flag capture does not grant a bonus activation. The turn continues with its normal budget.

After all three opponent flags are captured, your Captain must reach Space(3,3) to win.

FLAG AND NEXUS EDGE CASES

One flag per activation. A Captain captures at most one flag per activation. The geometry of the board makes simultaneous flag threats physically impossible (flags lie on different layers, separated by Lift transit), but the rule holds in principle: each flag capture is its own activation, resolved at step 3 of the turn sequence.

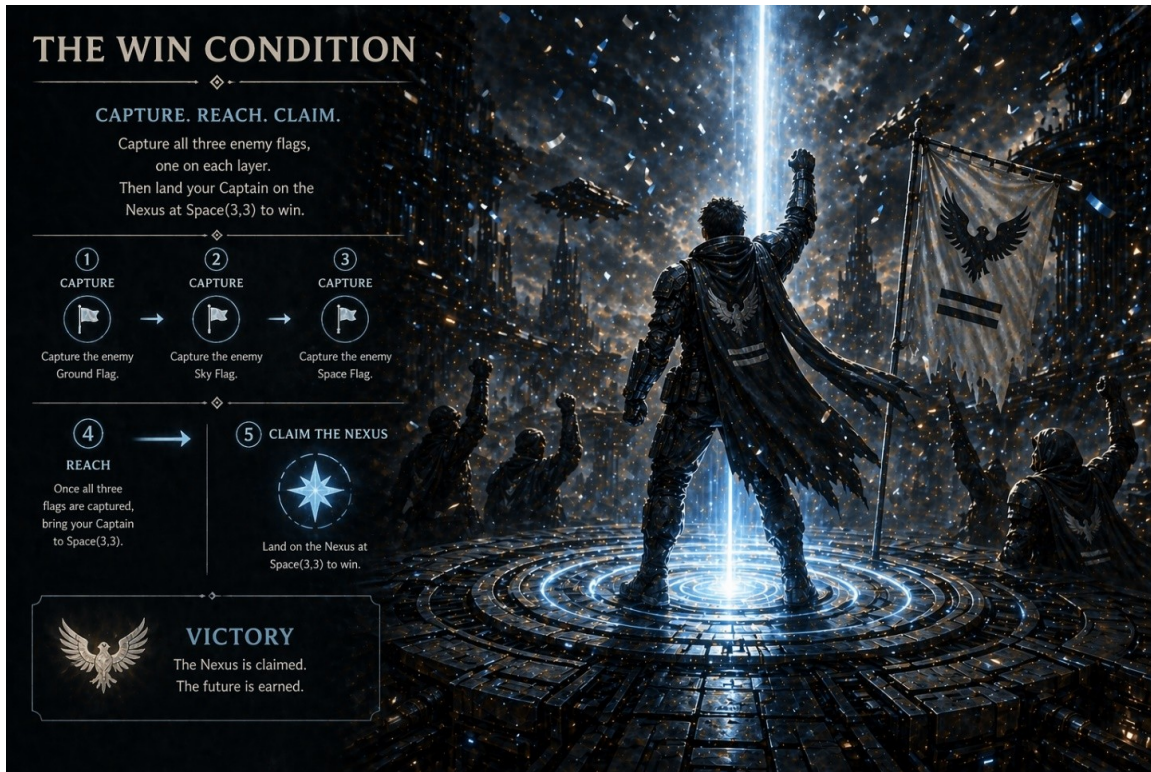
Nexus landing preconditions. For a Nexus landing to trigger the Path of Three win, three conditions must hold: (1) the moving piece is a Captain (original or promoted), (2) all three opponent flags have already been captured, and (3) the move is a normal king-move into Space(3,3), not a Lift step. A Captain that arrives at Space(3,3) without satisfying all three conditions simply occupies the cell; the win does not register, and the cell may be vacated on a later turn.

The Aetheri Echo Point

Each player's Ground and Space flags share the same (row, col), the Aetheri Echo Point. Continuity of position across layers was the proof the Aetheri required. The Sky flag sits at the diagonally opposite corner, enforcing a genuine horizontal traverse on the central layer.

7 • Win Conditions

Condition	How it triggers
Path of Three (constructive)	A Captain on your side captures all three of your opponent's flags (Ground, Sky, and Space, in any order) and then lands on the Nexus cell at Space(3,3). Either the original Captain or a promoted Captain may trigger this win. Flag-capture progress is shared across both Captains. The Nexus-landing action must be a normal move on the Empyrean (a king-move into Space(3,3)), not a Lift step.
Path of the Captain (eliminative)	Your opponent has no Captain on the board, no piece in hand that could deploy as a Captain, and no Soldier remaining that could promote to Captain at the far row. Every Captain-capable piece your opponent had has been permanently captured. This is the Thresan equivalent of checkmate: not a threat against a single piece, but the removal of every line by which the opponent could ever stand at the Nexus.
Win by Resignation [NEW v20]	Your opponent resigns the game from the in-game toolbar. The win is recorded as a resignation in the stats.
Win by Timeout [NEW v20]	If a time control is in effect and your opponent's clock reaches zero, you win immediately. Time controls are optional and default to off.
Draw by Agreement [NEW v20]	Either player may offer a draw at any time; if accepted, the game ends with no winner.
Turn-limit Draw	180 turns without a win. Tiebreak, in order: (1) flags captured; (2) pieces remaining; (3) opponent pieces captured; (4) highest layer occupied; (5) Captain Chebyshev distance to Space(3,3).



Stylized overview of the Nexus path. Definitive rules are in the table above.

Competitive Note

Thresan: Skyflag contains a minor structural asymmetry in its spatial geometry. Specifically, Space(3,3) is not equidistant from the Player 1 (P1) and Player 2 (P2) starting positions when evaluated through optimal Captain movement paths. Under efficient play, P1 can reach this key space in 18 actions, whereas P2 requires 19. This one-action differential introduces a slight first-player advantage, analogous to the initiative observed for White in Chess. To mitigate this imbalance in competitive play, matches are structured as a best-of-three series, with players alternating starting positions between games. This format ensures that each player has equal exposure to both positional advantages over the course of the match.

8 • Game Phases

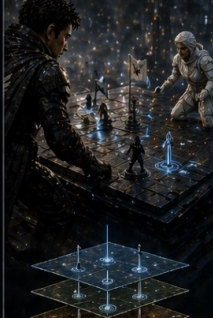
The three-flag system with a Nexus finish creates four natural phases of play. Flags may be pursued in any order, but the geometry rewards a sequential path.

Phase	Layer	What happens
1 • Ground Race	Ground	Both Captains on Ground racing across the board to capture the opposing Ground Flag. Soldiers deploy during play. Rovers and Pilots may ascend to Sky or Space immediately. Early Lift skirmishes determine approach control. ~3 to 4 rounds.
2 • Sky Crossing	Sky	Sky transit is the hardest leg: the target Sky Flag is diagonally opposite from the Lift nearest your Ground approach (four king-moves). Both Captains must cross the full board width in Sky. Most contested phase. ~4 to 5 rounds.
3 • Space Flag	Space	After Sky, the Captain ascends to Space. With echoed corners, the target Space Flag sits at the same position as the target Ground Flag, immediate recognition, but the opponent may already be contesting the layer. ~2 to 3 rounds under competition.
4 • Nexus Finish	Space	With all three flags captured, the Captain must converge on Space(3,3). The Nexus is central, 2 or 3 king-moves from any Space Flag, and either Captain (original or promoted) can finish. 2 to 3 activations minimum.

THE GAME PHASES

A BATTLE OF REACH. A TEST OF PURPOSE.

1 OPENING
Establish and advance.
Pieces begin in their starting positions. Take the initiative and move into position.



Establish control.
Plan your route.
Watch your opponent.

2 MIDGAME
Clash and capture.
Engage the enemy, capture their flags, and fight for the advantage.



Capture one flag on each layer.
Any order.

3 ASCENT
Use the Lifts.
Move through the Lifts to shift layers and shorten the distance to your goal.



Four Lifts connect all three layers.
Move. Shift. Adapt.

4 APPROACH
Seize the moment.
With all three flags captured, push your Captain toward the Nexus at Space(3,3).



All three flags captured?
Now the final reach begins.

5 RESOLUTION
Claim the Nexus.
Land your Captain on the Nexus at Space(3,3) to win the game.



Land on the Nexus.
Victory is earned.
The future is yours.

REMEMBER



CAPTURE
Enemy flags give you the right to approach the Nexus.



LIFTS
Move between layers. One layer per turn.



PROTECT
Guard your Captain. Losing your Captain ends your turn.



REACH
The Nexus is only on Space layer at (3,3). That is where it ends.

Stylized overview (five-act illustration). The definitive phase structure is the four-phase table above.

thresan.com

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9 • Play Modes

NEW IN v 2 0

Thresan: Skyflag is the same game in every mode. These mode descriptions document how it is actually played on the digital editions (thresan.com on web and iOS); the rules above govern all of them.

Solo vs AI

Single-player against a computer opponent. The AI uses an iterative-deepening minimax search with alpha-beta pruning, transposition table, killer-move and history heuristic move ordering, a piece-square table evaluator, and a small opening book. Four difficulty levels:

Difficulty	Search depth	Best for
Easy	2 ply	First-time players learning the geometry.
Medium	3 ply	Once you have won a few Easy games.
Hard	4 ply	Default for confident players.
Expert • Plus	6 ply	Sterner opponent. Requires the Plus subscription.

Difficulty is set in Settings, AI difficulty. The choice persists across sessions.

Two-Player Hot-Seat

Two humans sharing one device. Pass after each turn. No clock by default; enable a clock from Settings, Clock for a timed game. No account required.

Online Multiplayer

Two humans on separate devices, real-time over the network. Both players sign in (guest, email, Apple, or Google) and either create a room or join one by code. Sessions sync via Supabase realtime; push notifications fire on your turn if the app is not focused.

Ratings. Every completed online game updates both players ELO ratings. K-factor 24.

Friends. Save opponents nicknames; see who is online and challenge directly.

Tournaments. Round-robin and bracketed events. Free events open to all; entry-fee events require the Tournament Entry entitlement.

Daily Puzzle

One shared tactical position per day. The same starting position is served to every player worldwide; solve as efficiently as you can. A briefing screen presents the objective and a short rules recap before the position is revealed.

Time Controls

Optional. Default off. When a clock is in effect, each player has the chosen budget for the entire game; there is no per-move increment. If your clock reaches zero, you lose by Timeout.

Option	Per side	Best for
Off	No clock	Untimed casual play.
5 minutes	5 min	Blitz, fast, decisive.
10 minutes	10 min	Rapid, most online matches.
30 minutes	30 min	Classical, thoughtful play.

Resignation and Draw Offers

Either player may resign at any time from the in-game toolbar. Either may also offer a draw; the opponent accepts or declines. A resignation is recorded as a loss for the resigner; an accepted draw counts as a draw for both. In solo play, the AI willingness to accept a draw depends on the position evaluation; if the AI believes it is winning, it will decline.

10 • Quick Reference

Keep this page beside the board during play.

Rule	Summary
Win	Two paths. (1) Path of Three: capture all 3 opponent flags (any order), then land your Captain on Space(3,3). (2) Path of the Captain: opponent has no Captain on the board, none in hand, and no Soldier that could promote.
P1 targets	G(5,5) · Sky(5,0) · Space(5,5)
P2 targets	G(0,0) · Sky(0,5) · Space(0,0)
Nexus	Space(3,3), shared finish cell.
Lifts	(1,1) · (1,4) · (4,1) · (4,4). Same on all layers. Two-turn transit. Not within king-move of each other.
Lift occupation	Piece above or below blocks the Lift step from the adjacent layer. The step cannot capture.
Activations	2 per turn. Flag capture does not grant a bonus.
Captain	King-move (1 sq, 8 dirs, all layers). Capture by landing. Flag-capable. Wins on Space(3,3).
Soldier	Forward-only. First move ≤ 2 sq. Capture: diagonal-forward. Promotes to Captain at the far row on Ground.
Rover	Orthogonal ≤ 2 sq. Capture at 1 step only.
Pilot	Diagonal ≤ 2 sq. May jump an intervening piece to capture beyond.
Promotion	Soldier reaching far row on Ground becomes a Captain. Can capture flags, trigger the Path of Three, and counts as Captain-capable for the Path of the Captain.
Any layer	Any piece may ascend or descend via Lift at any time.
Turn limit	180 turns. Tiebreak: flags > pieces > captures > layer > distance to Space(3,3).
Clock [NEW]	Optional 5 / 10 / 30 minutes per side. Zero clock = Timeout loss.
Resign / Draw [NEW]	Either player may resign or offer a draw at any time.

Thresan

S K Y F L A G

Rulebook · v22 · Cross-Board Rule
Where strategists gather.

Three Layers · Four Lifts · One Nexus

Ashtapada · Thresan · Skyflag · Kaleo

thresan.com

Heritage and design notes: ashtapada.com

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Game design and rulebook: Dr. Nelson Jatel, P.Ag.